

Statements & Assumptions

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Statements-and-assumptions questions give a statement (often an advertisement, policy announcement, or argument) followed by one or more numbered assumptions, and ask which assumption is 'implicit' — that is, a belief the speaker **MUST** take for granted for the statement to make sense, even though it isn't written down. An assumption is not just any true or plausible-sounding fact; it must be something the argument genuinely **DEPENDS** on, such that if it were false, the statement would fall apart or make no sense. The standard test for this is the negation test: negate the candidate assumption and check whether the original statement is weakened or becomes illogical — if the statement stays perfectly reasonable even under the negation, that candidate was never a true assumption. This sub-module covers the definition and negation test, distinguishing assumptions from restatements and general knowledge, common assumption patterns in advertisements and notices, and several fully worked question sets.

1. What Counts as an Implicit Assumption

An assumption is an **UNSTATED** premise that the statement's speaker must believe to be true for their statement, suggestion, or action to be logically sound — it is not something explicitly said (that would just be a stated fact) and not something the statement merely implies as a conclusion (that would be an inference). The assumption sits **BEHIND** the statement, propping it up.

- Statement: 'Buy brand X toothpaste — recommended by dentists.' Implicit assumption: 'At least some customers trust dentist recommendations when choosing a toothpaste.' Without this belief, citing a dentist recommendation as a selling point would make no sense as an advertising strategy.

2. The Negation Test

To verify whether a candidate is a genuine assumption, negate it (assume it is **FALSE**) and re-read the original statement — if the statement now seems pointless, illogical, or self-contradictory, the candidate **WAS** a necessary assumption. If the statement still makes perfect sense even with the candidate negated, that candidate was never actually assumed.

- Statement: 'The school has decided to introduce a bus service so that students living far away can attend regularly.' Candidate assumption: 'Some students currently face difficulty attending due to distance.' Negate it: 'No students face difficulty due to distance' — under this negation, introducing a bus service for that reason makes no sense. So the candidate **IS** a valid assumption (it passes the negation test).

3. Assumptions vs Restatements and General Knowledge

A common wrong-answer trap restates a fact already given in the statement (not an assumption, since it's already explicit) or cites a general truth about the world that the argument doesn't actually rely on — the negation test catches both: negating a restatement usually directly contradicts the given statement (making it look 'too obviously true' to be the intended trap), while negating an unrelated general truth leaves the original statement completely unaffected.

- Statement: 'Enrollment in the evening batch has doubled this year, so the institute plans to open a second evening batch.' Candidate: 'Evening batches are generally popular with working professionals' (general knowledge, not something this specific decision depends on) — negate it: even if evening batches weren't generally popular, THIS institute's doubled enrollment alone still justifies opening a second batch. So this candidate is NOT a necessary assumption, despite sounding plausible.

4. Common Assumption Patterns in Advertisements

Advertisements almost always assume that (a) at least some portion of the target audience will be influenced by the specific claim being made, and (b) the feature being advertised is something the audience doesn't already universally have or know — these two patterns cover a large fraction of advertisement-based assumption questions.

- Ad: '50% extra free, only this month!' Assumption: 'At least some customers are motivated to buy more when offered a limited-time quantity bonus.' (Not an assumption: 'All customers are motivated by discounts' — 'all' is too strong; ads only need SOME customers to respond, so an 'all'-worded option usually overstates the necessary assumption.)

5. Common Assumption Patterns in Policy/Notice Statements

Notices and policy statements ('The library will now close at 6 PM instead of 8 PM') typically assume that the new arrangement is feasible/implementable and that it will not defeat the very purpose the institution serves — checking whether the assumption is about FEASIBILITY (can this actually be done) or about the stated goal not being undermined is a fast way to categorize the assumption.

- Notice: 'All employees must swipe their ID cards to enter the office from Monday.' Assumption: 'ID card swipe machines are available and functioning for all employees' — without this being true, the policy as stated couldn't actually be carried out.

6. Multiple-Assumption Questions (I and II)

When two numbered assumptions are given and the answer choices ask whether 'only I', 'only II', 'both', or 'neither' is implicit, apply the negation test to each INDEPENDENTLY — do not let your judgment on one assumption bias your reading of the other, since it's common for exactly one of the two to pass and the other to be a plausible-sounding overreach.

- Statement: 'Company X has asked all its employees to work from home twice a week to reduce office costs.' Assumption I: 'Employees have the infrastructure (internet, workspace) to work from home.' Assumption II: 'Employees prefer working from home over the office.' Negate I: if employees had no home infrastructure, the policy couldn't function — I is a valid assumption. Negate II: even if employees didn't prefer it, the company could still mandate it for cost reasons — II is NOT necessary. Answer: only I is implicit.

7. Working Through a Full Example

Combine the negation test with a check for overly strong ('all', 'always', 'only') wording, since assumption questions frequently offer a correctly-themed but too-strongly-worded distractor alongside the correctly-scoped answer.

- Statement: 'Please switch off the lights when leaving the room to save electricity.' Assumption A: 'Lights left on consume electricity unnecessarily.' Assumption B: 'Everyone who reads this notice will always comply.' A passes the negation test (if lights didn't consume extra electricity when left on, the notice would be pointless). B fails — the notice doesn't depend on 100% compliance to make sense as a request; it's a reasonable hope, not a load-bearing assumption. Answer: A only.

Common Pitfalls

- Treating a widely-held but unstated belief as an assumption when the argument doesn't actually depend on it (it passes as 'plausible' but fails the negation test).
- Selecting an option that merely restates a fact already given in the statement instead of identifying a genuinely implicit, unstated premise.
- Choosing an assumption worded with 'all/always/only/never' when the statement only requires a weaker, partial version of that belief to hold.
- Skipping the negation test and instead judging assumptions by gut feel, which is unreliable on deliberately similar-sounding answer choices.
- Confusing an assumption (something believed to make the statement work) with a conclusion or inference (something that follows FROM the statement).
- Assuming general world knowledge is automatically a valid assumption, even when the specific argument doesn't actually rely on that general fact.
- Letting judgment on one numbered assumption (I) bias the independent negation test applied to another (II) in the same question.

Key Takeaways

- An assumption is an unstated belief the statement **DEPENDS** on — not a restated fact, not general knowledge, and not a conclusion drawn from the statement.
- Apply the negation test: if negating the candidate makes the original statement illogical or pointless, it **IS** a valid assumption.

- Advertisements typically assume only that SOME of the audience will respond to the claim — reject options overstated with 'all' or 'every'.
- Policy/notice statements typically assume either feasibility of implementation or that the goal isn't undermined — categorize the assumption accordingly.
- In multi-assumption (I/II) questions, apply the negation test to each option completely independently.
- Prefer the more narrowly and weakly worded assumption over a stronger one when both pass the negation test — arguments usually need only the minimal belief.

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IndiaBix — Statement and Assumption

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